

Saint Cyril of Alexandria

Commentary on Psalm 50

When David, in the preceding psalm, had heard the Spirit prophesying concerning the judgment of God and charging the sinner—"If you saw a thief, you ran with him, and with adulterers you set your portion" (Psalm 49:18)—struck in mind by the memory of his theft and of the violated marriage-bed, he strove to anticipate the judgment of God, composing the psalm set before him as an indictment against himself. For he feared when he heard: "For God shall come manifestly, and fire shall burn before him, and a mighty tempest shall be round about him" (Psalm 49:3). Therefore he fled to the mercy of God. And again, hearing: "Your mouth has abounded with wickedness, and your tongue has framed deceits: sitting you spoke against your brother, and against the son of your mother you laid a stumbling-block" (Psalm 49:19-20); there came to his mind the treacherous letter which he had written against Uriah, so that he might be removed from the midst in battle. And he said: "For I know my iniquity" (Psalm 50:5). And again: "Deliver me from blood, O God" (Psalm 50:16). And when he heard again, "I will reprove you, and set my face against you" (Psalm 49:21), he said: "Turn away your face from my sins" (Psalm 50:11). Moreover, when he heard again, "I will not receive bullocks from your house, nor he-goats from your flocks" (Psalm 49:9), he added to this: "For if you had desired sacrifice, I would surely have given it" (Psalm 50:18). Now the things concerning Uriah, as well as Nathan's reproof, are written in the second book of Samuel (2 Samuel 11–12). But before Nathan came to him, he did not confess, being weighed down by sin as by

sleep and drunkenness. Nor did the Prophet visit him immediately after the sin. For that word, "The iniquities of the Amorites are not yet full" (Genesis 15:16), might also be said of David. For it was not fitting that his free will should be hindered and grow worse while wickedness lay hidden in the depths. But when he had brought all his evil into the open, and the disease had subsided with the passage of time and taken a stable condition, then indeed the prophet, like a skilled physician, applied a timely remedy by reproof and rebuking, when the passion was no longer growing rank or boiling over. Rightly therefore does Scripture mark the time also, saying: "And he brought her, after the death of her husband, into his house to David, and she became his wife, and bore him a son; and the thing appeared evil" (2 Samuel 11:27). The thing that David had done displeased the Lord; and the Lord sent Nathan to David (2 Samuel 12:1), so that this took place after the space of a full year. Before that, however, while his mind was still troubled, he would either not have endured being reproofed, or would have resolved something severe against the prophet, like those who are frantic in mental illness and turn on parents and dearest friends, indeed even on their physicians. What, then, was the cause of so great a sin in so great a man? Nathan himself taught this when he brought forward his example: he says that there were two men, one rich, namely David, and the other poor, namely Uriah (2 Samuel 12:1–2); then he introduces a traveling stranger who on his journey had turned aside to lodge with the rich man, implying that a certain stranger spirit had approached the soul of David—for without diabolical power so great a man would never have fallen into such madness, he who had preserved continence in the flower of his age. For when he fled from

Saul in the desert, he had Ahinoam; he had Abigail after the death of her husband; but he seems never to have approached them throughout the whole time of his exile: for he had no children except after the death of Saul. For the time of exile was a time for prayer and supplication. But when he had gained the kingdom, Scripture relates that sons were born to him at Hebron. And when Solomon knew this spirit that overturns great souls, he said: "If the spirit of him who has power rise up against you, do not leave your place" (Ecclesiastes 10:4).

Verse 3. Have mercy on me, O God, according to your great mercy.

Nothing so greatly inclines the Lord to mercy as the confession of sin: therefore David also asks that all mercy be poured out upon him and the whole fountain of compassions be poured out over him. For as he asks for the greatness of mercy, so he implores the multitude of mercies, because it was a great sin and could not be blotted out except by fitting clemency. Certainly to wash hands stained with murder is solely the office of God's mercy. But he who fashioned nature pities her: for he knows that she, sick with much weakness, is easily drawn away to unclean passions of the flesh. For the inventor of sin easily preys upon the human mind, having as his helper the law raging in the fleshly members. Therefore the physician of spirits must be sought, that he may restore good health to the mind; for all strength comes from him. Perhaps, however, because David foresaw that in the course of time Christ would appear to men, to blot out all the sins of the world, he rightly calls so outstanding a grace "great mercy." For it is written: "Every sin shall stop up his mouth" (Psalm 105:42). For, as the Apostle says: "God who justifies—who is he

that condemns?" (Romans 8:33). Now the Greeks call this kind of sin, which is brought about by a double transgression of the law.

Verse 4. Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, etc.

He who says, "Wash me yet more" (Psalm 50:4)—here again, as is fitting, observe the mystery of Christ. The law fell short in purgation by water, of which the wisest Paul also makes mention, saying: "For if the blood of bulls and goats, and the ashes of a heifer sprinkled, sanctify those who are defiled, unto the cleansing of the flesh" (Hebrews 9:13). Yet the type was powerless for the washing away of sin and conferred only purification of the flesh; but the grace and power of Christ and of baptism, surpassing the legal purification, cleanses more fully; indeed, it purges the soul itself most completely.

Verse 6. Against you alone have I sinned, etc.

The wicked man is he who says to a king, "You sin"—so divine Scripture says somewhere (Ecclesiastes 10:20). Since, then, there was no one who could rebuke the sinner, and you alone were a suitable corrector, therefore: "Against you only have I sinned" (Psalm 50:6). And rightly he added, "And I have done evil before you" (Psalm 50:6); for indeed this too is recorded in history, namely, that that deed was seen to be wrong before the Lord (2 Samuel 11:27).

"That you may be justified in your words, and may prevail when you are judged."

Truly, he says, I was the author of evils, but your justice shines out even from this. For if judgment is set up, and your good deeds toward me are brought out into the open, and my works are set over against them, you will indeed appear just and merciful, but I am a transgressor and ungrateful. Therefore the particle ἵνα (hina) by no means denotes the causal sense in this place: for David did not sin in order that God might be justified; but rather, on the contrary, God's justice is shown from his sin. For God exercises provident care over all men.

Verse 7. For behold, I was conceived in iniquities.

He says this, not because sin is a natural operation; for then punishment could not be exacted from him; but because frailty is inherent in nature. Yet the same becomes victorious through its own purpose and labor, and is not held by necessity, because of free will. Perhaps even the captives in Babylon, as some suppose, say to God: If you demand the penalties of my sins from me, you must now demand the same from the forefathers as well; for not even they were grateful for your benefits. I therefore received from my fathers, as it were in place of an inheritance, to be ungrateful, and from them I contract sin.

It is the custom of the saints to propitiate God and move him to mercy, sometimes with many words, sometimes also by urgently accusing the clinging weakness of human nature. Therefore we hear them crying out: "Remember, O Lord, that we are dust" (Psalm 102:14). "Man's days are as grass, and as the flower of the field, so shall he flourish" (Psalm 102:15). Also: "Remember what my substance is" (Psalm 138:16). But Job, most patient of men,

explaining this more clearly, cried out to God: "Have you not milked me like milk, and curdled me like cheese? You have clothed me with skin and flesh; you have knit me together with bones and sinews; you have placed life and mercy with me" (Job 10:10–12). We say that the same thing is signified now also in the preceding verses. For David affirms that the very beginning of our birth comes about not without the filth of carnal pleasure. Marriages are without doubt honorable, and beyond all reproach before God. Yet if anyone traces the reason for entering into marriage, he will find it to be desire of the flesh; although the act itself is not reckoned as sin. But sexual union is condemned unless it has the support of law, and unless the bearing of children is the true end of the matter. Therefore, as regards carnal desires and movements alone, we are conceived in iniquities, and our mothers conceive in sins. But if carnal affection has its root in the generation of bodies, it follows that this condition is plainly diseased, and whatever proceeds from it. Hence the most sacred Paul complains at length of carnal movements, saying: "For I delight in the law of God according to the inner man: but I see another law in my members, warring against the law of my mind, and making me captive to the law of sin which is in my members. O wretched man that I am, who shall deliver me from the body of this death? Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord" (Romans 7:22–25), through whom the law of sin was mitigated and the onslaught of carnal movements was mortified. And this, among other good gifts, has been granted us by the only-begotten Word of God made man. How fittingly the divine Paul bears witness to the matter: "For what the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh, God, sending his own Son in the

likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh, that the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit" (Romans 8:3–4).

Verse 8. For behold, you have loved the truth; you have made known to me the hidden things of your wisdom.

He showed that human nature had already from the beginning succumbed to sin because of Eve's transgression, and that each one's birth is subject to the curse. But he weaves the discourse at greater length to show the greatness of the divine gift, in that God has plainly rescued us from so long a curse by the washing of regeneration. Now in this place the word truth seems to name a sincere life lived with truth and justice: for whoever is unwilling to live in this way lies to God. For man was brought forth into the light in order to do good, as the wisest Paul says (Ephesians 5:8); if he becomes wicked, he lies to his Creator, because he does not bear the fruit of justice. Thus elsewhere holy David also says in the person of Christ to the Israelites: "The sons of strangers have lied to me" (Psalm 17:46). Likewise: "The fruit of the olive tree will prove false" (Psalm 127:3). But you may also interpret it another way: namely, that the law is weak in cleansing sin, in that it sprinkles water for the washing of the flesh. But the grace of Christ is incomparably better, able to destroy every kind of filth. Thus God testifies that he loves truth. Moreover, truth is Christ and the things that proceed from him, as opposed to the law, type, and shadow. You therefore, he says, O Lord, who are truth and love truth, willing that we spend our life in truth, have also washed away our ancient sin for us, that we may be made white as snow (Psalm 50:9). But the

phrase "Hidden things you have made manifest to me" indicates that all things to come, which God has hidden in the treasury of his wisdom, have been revealed through the Holy Spirit. Perhaps he also exaggerates his sin, in order to strike into himself greater shame, affirming that he did not sin in ignorance, but was conscious of the law, and after he had been adorned not only with the benefits of the kingdom but also with the gift of prophecy. Therefore, once he has shown the seriousness of his guilt, he next asks for absolution, saying:

"You shall sprinkle me with hyssop, and I shall be cleansed."

By hyssop he compares the operation of the Holy Spirit, a heating herb that cleanses every stain of ours. Purgation will therefore be brought about either through hyssop or through the Holy Spirit. For hyssop is said to be a very hot herb, endowed with styptic power; physicians too hold it in high esteem, as a draught fit for destroying the filth of the entrails and for dissolving constrictions, phlegm, and the concretion and thickness of the other humors, because of the efficacy of the natural heat within it. He therefore indirectly hints at the operation of the Holy Spirit that takes place in us, who by his grace makes our soul fervent and removes every stain from us, poured out invisibly like fire. Therefore inspired men say that we are baptized by Christ "with the Holy Spirit and with fire" (Matthew 3:11). But the precious blood of Christ frees us not only from corruption, but also from every hidden inner impurity, and does not allow sloth to grow cold.

Verse 10. You shall make me hear exultation and gladness, etc.

"You will take care," he says, "that I may hear the most holy exultation that is to come in the last times." What then is this, except that knowledge of the resurrection? He also signified this when he said: "And the bones that were humbled shall rejoice" (Psalm 50:10). When indeed shall corrupted bones rejoice, except at the time of the resurrection, when, as the prophecy says, "Our bones shall sprout like grass" (Ezekiel 37:5)? Fittingly he added to the aforesaid words, "You shall sprinkle me" (Psalm 50:9): for the hope of the resurrection follows the grace of holy baptism, referring those who believe in Christ to the beginnings of that immortal and most blessed life. For then "the just shall shine as the sun" (Matthew 13:43), and, enjoying goods that surpass the mind, they shall possess everlasting gladness. Therefore purification through holy baptism takes place at once and in a single act; for in Christ the grace of the Holy Spirit is given, sanctifying and cleansing the hearts of believers. Yet it is heard, and up to now hope has not failed, concerning the good things to come—exultation and gladness. Indeed, according to some interpreters, exultation and gladness sounding in divine hearings do not appear to be a different thing from this very giver, Christ, who will renew and raise up the strength of individual souls that have suffered contrition. For bones here must be understood to denote the vigor of the mind. But to state it more simply: "I shall hear," he says, "the voice of exultation," namely, that my twofold sin has been forgiven.

Verse 11. Turn away your face from my sins.

Look not, he says, upon my iniquities, but rather upon me who deplore them. But to ask for these things is nothing other than to

wish that the grace of Christ be given to the inhabitants of the earth.

Verse 12. Create in me a clean heart, O God.

In holy Scripture, creation is called not only an effecting from nothing, but also the advancement of an existing thing into something better. God created the heavens: that is to make from nothing. He also creates when he has made a bad man good; here indeed creation is a change for the better. For hear David himself, who, although he had long been created with his own heart, yet because he had made himself guilty of adultery and murder and was rushing into corruption, says, "Create in me a clean heart" (Psalm 50:12)—not that he lacked a heart before, nor speaking of the substance of the soul, but of the best kind of life. Perhaps also, as though the heart of all were polluted because of Adam's transgression and bent into vice, the saints ask that a certain reformation of our condition be brought about by the Creator of all, who knows our nature and is able to do all things, which he has in fact also done. For we have been reformed in Christ through the newness of our mind, and we bear a pure heart, turned to the pursuit of virtue.

Verse 13. Do not cast me away from your face, and do not take your Holy Spirit from me.

David, moved by what had befallen him, takes on the person of the human race and prays on behalf of the whole world. For from Adam's transgression, or from the beginning of the race, human nature has been turned away from God; therefore it was cast out of paradise and became accursed, though it had previously been

blessed by the Creator. Now, as the multitude of the race grew and the tyranny of sin pressed upon all, that holy Spirit of God breathed into us also withdrew, and the beauty of the image was destroyed. For the God of all said, "My Spirit shall not remain in such men, for they are flesh" (Genesis 6:3). When he therefore says, "Do not cast me away from your face, and do not take your Holy Spirit from me" (Psalm 50:13), he asks for two things at once: namely, an end to the aversion that had taken place, and the return of the Holy Spirit to us. That it withdrew justly and deservedly—because the heart of all is prone to wickedness from youth—he shows clearly from what is written: for the thought of man's heart is prone to evil from his youth (Genesis 8:21). Yet none the less he asks God's clemency that the evils which came upon us beyond hope should cease; and this is the same as the restoration of the Holy Spirit who had withdrawn from us, which in fact came about through Christ, who, assuming our likeness, removed the aversion, presenting in himself a pure and blameless human nature to God the Father. He also received the Spirit; although, as is easily understood, he himself is truly the giver of the Spirit whom the Father sends into men through Christ. He therefore breathed upon the apostles, saying, "Receive the Holy Spirit" (John 20:22). For so also at the beginning of the world was it given to human nature.

Verse 14. Restore to me the joy of your salvation.

He asks to become a partaker of human nature in the first blessings, which in fact comes about through Christ the mediator, who is joy and salvation. For he has freed us from the sorrow of corruption, death having been destroyed; and we have been saved, with sin cast

off through most holy baptism, and have been strengthened by the princely Spirit—understood in two words as the strength given by the Holy Spirit. If anyone receives this and fixes it in his mind, he will wholly rule his desires and overcome the diabolical power, having the Spirit within him as prince and guide. For "as many as," says Scripture, "are led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God" (Romans 8:14); and again: "Walk by the Spirit, and you will not fulfill the desire of the flesh" (Galatians 5:16).

Verse 16. My tongue shall exult in your righteousness.

Or also in this way: your spiritual feast will take justice as its theme—justice which justifies the impious through the grace of faith, that is, through our Lord Jesus Christ himself, who has been given to us by God the Father as righteousness, sanctification, and redemption (1 Corinthians 1:30).

Verse 17. Lord, you will open my lips.

Nature has so arranged that guilt binds the tongue and stops up the mouth. Therefore, because David's lips too had been closed by sin, he asks that they be opened and recover their former confidence. "You will open my lips," he says (Psalm 50:17), because this is God's work: "There is no beautiful praise in the mouth of a sinner" (Sirach 15:9). The mouth, however, is opened through repentance, and then begins to praise God. The captives too (Psalm 136:4), because they were not allowed to sing God's song in a foreign land or to offer sacrifice, ask for their return home.

Verse 19. A sacrifice to God is a broken spirit.

The power of spiritual worship is not exercised in the mind alone, but is always accustomed to have as its companion the fragrance of good works, which obedience and docility produce. We say, moreover, that obedience is the fruit of a soft and tractable heart, having nothing rigid—unlike the heart of the ruthless Jews, which was hard and unteachable. Therefore, putting on their person, a certain holy prophet said, "Why have you made us err, O Lord, from your way, and hardened our hearts, so that we should not fear you?" (Isaiah 63:17). Surely hard hearts are wholly incapable of God's teaching. Therefore not without cause is the sacrifice and the oblation of spiritual fragrance acceptable to God: a contrite spirit (Psalm 50:19), that is, a soft soul obedient to the divine sayings.

Verse 20. Do good, O Lord, in your good pleasure to Zion.

According to the anagoge, when you deal kindly toward Zion—that is, the Church—as you restore all things in the Son with good pleasure, and when the walls of the Church are built, namely the priests and teachers of this stronghold, then sacrifices will be offered, not bloody, but of justice and praise. Likewise, both the oblation and the burnt offering will consist of justice.

Verse 21. Then they will lay calves upon your altar.

The calf is a sacred and legitimate animal; for it is offered in sacrifice because it is pure, and is also larger than the goat and the sheep. By the very size of its body it bears the type of the most perfect sacrifice, ascending to the heavenly seats of spiritual fragrance. For the bulk of the body is seen as an image of spiritual greatness, insofar as it is understood of the virtues. "They will place

calves upon your altar," he says—that is, the most perfect sacrifices. Or perhaps in this place he names calves, by enigma, as teachers of the peoples, because of the spiritual strength of mind, whose life is also sacred. The wisest Paul suggests these meanings to us when he cites what is written in the law: "You shall not muzzle the ox while it treads out the grain" (Deuteronomy 25:4; 1 Corinthians 9:9), then adding, "Is God concerned for oxen? Or does he say this altogether for our sake?"